

To what extent is increased affluence the reason for our environmental problems today?

□ This essay cogently argues that increased global prosperity around the world is mostly responsible for our environmental woes.

- ◆ Incorporating a variety of opinions from the perspective of different parties, Xingyi crafts a persuasive essay which argues that increased affluence is significantly responsible for environmental problems today.
- ◆ Interesting, relevant and contemporary examples are provided alongside examples traditionally raised as evidence of Mother Nature being sacrificed for economic growth. This indicates the candidate's awareness of both past and present trends.
- ◆ This essay could have been further improved if Man's food choices and eating habits – as a result of increasing incomes – had been addressed. This would have allowed for the incorporation of an even wider range of environmental problems that food choices by the affluent have created, such as deforestation and climate change.

[1] The plastic water bottles that line the aisles of supermarkets, convenience stores and even vending machines are the epitome of the wastefulness of resources in the modern developed world. [2] Looking past the fact that these distilled water bottles are essentially packaging a free resource available from our taps; the irony of using a whopping 3 litres of water to make a 1 litre plastic bottle will also probably not be lost on the educated consumer. Indeed, it might seem illogical to invest our precious resources in production methods that yield so little, but the fact is that we tend to choose convenience over conservation. Some point to increased affluence as the reason for such behaviors, due to the increased consumption brought about by an increase in purchasing power; yet detractors argue that it is not just affluence, but rather moral corruption that has led to us desecrating the environment. [3] Even if increased affluence has enabled us to ameliorate the trend of environmental degradation. I believe that increased affluence is still largely responsible for our environmental problems.

[4] The narrative of the poor country becoming rich at breakneck speed has been exhausted in recent years - China and India being the most apt examples of how previously flailing economies can now flourish. But at the same time, we are also acutely aware of the ramifications of such astronomical growth; both countries hardly see smog-less days and a host of environmental problems such as polluted waterways or toxic land waste seem to plague them endlessly. Yet, all

[1] An impactful introduction that begins with an astute observation.

[2] This ironic statistic effectively highlights the absurdity of our production methods and their environmental consequences.

[3] There is a clear and balanced thesis.

[4] The writer acknowledges that she is using a cliché but reminds us of its continued relevance.

this can be extrapolated to the results of an increased affluence, not only domestically, but worldwide. As the world's economies continue to expand, an increase in the wealth of citizens also proportionally causes more exorbitant and reckless spending patterns. [5] "Tu Hao", a Chinese term referring to millionaires from rural areas of China that have struck rich and whom are marked by their lavish lifestyles and their characteristics of carrying around thousands of dollars in cash, exemplify the global rising middle class and their newly acquired purchasing power. In order to feed their growing demand for consumer products, factories around the world have to produce exponentially more goods, sapping more of our precious resources. Furthermore, most production lines are environmentally unfriendly. China – the world's largest factory – has seen an increase in lung cancer cases due to toxic gases emitted by factories and lakes of green algae – a byproduct of eutrophication due to mishandling of toxic waste from factories. [6] Such scenes echo throughout the world's developing countries where production quotas matter more than the environment, as they seek to fulfill the consumerist desires of the first world as well as the *nouveau riche* in their own countries.

[7] Hence given that the bulk of consumption worldwide is met by such environmentally unfriendly production methods, the increased purchasing power of citizens and simultaneous demands for consumer goods is undoubtedly responsible for several of our environmental problems. [8] Even if products are produced with minimal pollution, such excessive consumerism still depletes our natural resources – a subset of environmental problems often overlooked. Therefore it is evident that higher consumption patterns due to increasing affluence are largely responsible for our environmental problems today.

[9] Critics who believe that increased affluence is not to be attributed to environmental degradation are quick to point out that the desire for economic progress is the real reason behind the environmental problems that we grapple with today. Indeed, governments around the world give up to \$330 billion of oil subsidies a year and many countries have indeed forsaken the environment for Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth. The Niger Delta, for example, is the third largest wasteland in the world with a huge diversity of animal and plant species. However, oil drilling approved by a government dazzled by profits has seen more than 6800 oil spills, severely

[5] This is an interesting example that gives the writer a good platform to make the link to the rising middle class and their changing consumption patterns all around the world.

[6] An effective and compelling concluding sentence.

[7] A clear link is shown between consumption patterns spurred by rising incomes and environmentally unfriendly methods of production.

[8] An effective argument is used here to show the inevitable link between growing wealth and resource depletion.

[9] Opponent's arguments are clearly articulated with appropriate discourse markers.

[10] A carefully crafted and

threatening the species of that habitat. [10] It does seem that the desire for progress is the main culprit here – but on closer examination, this is a vicious cycle – a desire for increased affluence by governments who implement economic policies that spur growth. Since greed is never-ending, such a cycle has become an endless chase for even more wealth, under the guise of 'progress'. [11] Ultimately, aspirations for increased affluence have led to an endless chase for wealth at all costs, and the environment has unfortunately become one of its casualties.

Other environmentalists also eagerly point fingers at corrupt officials for hampering environmental effects, but again, in the same vein, increased affluence is behind such corrupt behaviour. Indonesia, despite allocating a large proportion of the budget to environmental efforts, sees most of its state revenue squandered by corrupt officers. Local governments turn a blind eye to corporations who burn forests to clear land for plantations simply because of bribery. They do so despite thousands of complaints lodged by environmental advocacy groups such as Greenpeace as well as neighboring countries who suffer the aftermath of forest clearing – the Singapore government has repeatedly appealed to the Indonesian government to tackle the problem of illegal forest clearing, as the haze is a hazard even to the healthy and further disrupts the daily lives of individuals. Such pleas are made to no avail and the resultant effect is that Singapore and her neighboring countries face the effects of hazardous air quality annually. [12] But while corruption is to blame for hindering environmental efforts, an examination of motives of the corrupt would reveal that bribes are used to sustain their affluent lifestyles. The desire to maintain an affluent lifestyle is clearly a key motivation behind the developing world's half-baked attempts to preserve the environment.

[13] The strongest argument from the affluent who wish to shirk the responsibility of harming the environment is perhaps that with increased wealth, they are also able to ameliorate, if not reverse the damage inflicted on Earth.

[14] The largest photovoltaic solar plant – Desert Sunlight Power Plant opened just in February 2015. Located in the Mojave Desert in California, this plant is capable of supplying power to the entire Los Angeles region with minimal waste production. The world's most ambitious nuclear project 'Iter', meaning "the way" in Latin, is scheduled to be completed by 2020. Located in

concise rebuttal.

[11] It is noteworthy that the notion of 'increased wealth' is defined expansively, giving rise to the argument that a country's aspirations for prosperity, rather than just the accumulation of wealth are similarly detrimental to the environment.

[12] The need to maintain an affluent lifestyle is also well articulated in this paragraph as a significant contributory factor to environmental degradation.

[13] Again, the writer addresses a crucial perspective with appropriate discourse markers and signposts.

[14] The use of contemporary examples to support an opposing

the South of France where 34 nations have combined both wealth and expertise to produce a plant capable of harnessing power from the sun in a box without any detrimental environmental effects; it is argued that all this would not have been achieved without money. [15] Yet, a comparison of the pollution and degradation inflicted on the environment and the relatively miniscule and superficial efforts taken to ameliorate the devastating effects of decades of industrialization indicates that innovation and research and development is insufficient to absolve Mankind of the charge of ruining the planet. Until the developmental path to affluence is radically changed to include much cleaner production methods, or revolutionized by the rejection of reckless and extravagant consumption patterns; increased affluence will still have to bear the bulk of the blame for our current environmental problems.

[16] Thomas Jefferson famously remarked that "Money, not morality, is the principle commerce of the civilized nation". Today's consumerist societies bear testament to his words, proving that even the most enlightened of societies would sacrifice the environment for prosperity; where the wanton destruction of the Mother Earth is morally permissible and even sanctioned as long as economic imperatives are met. Overconsumption, graft, and wasteful extravagance have led to resource depletion, pollution and the destruction of ecosystems. While some have woken up to the idea that we need to salvage our environment before it destroys us, a great many are still oblivious to our impending doom. [17] Even though we establish that the desire for and maintenance of increased wealth is to blame for our environmental woes, finger pointing is futile unless collective action and responsibility is shouldered by the global community.

perspective is commendable here. Too often, strawman fallacies (refer to your logic and fallacies handbook in Year One) or tokenistic attempts are made to outline opposing viewpoints in essays.

[15] An effective rebuttal here that weighs the relative merits of modern environmentally-friendly technologies against the cumulative damage inflicted on Mother Earth through the centuries. This is used effectively to reinforce the writer's argument that increased affluence is still mainly to be blamed for the lamentable state of the environment today.

[16] An insightful and relevant quote that encapsulates the writer's thesis. This is followed in the next few lines by an equally commendable evaluation of the quotation and its relevance to the argument.

[17] A balanced and nuanced view is expressed towards the end of the essay, provoking further thought.